

Vista. There was more stability, hardware was used better, the User Account Control (UAC) was less of an irritant and boot times fell. Virtualization was better, and the silly Windows Sidebar was removed. Using data from W3C Schools, Windows 7 has a market penetration of 55%, Vista has 2.4%, XP has 19%, and Windows 8 is at a little under 6%.

## Windows 8



Windows 8 – no start menu

### Rating: Poor

We will dissect the failure of Windows 8 in the next article, but overall, the trend seems to suggest that Windows 9 might just be a rollicking success. It has to be, or else...

### Why did it happen?

Now that we've finished our little history lesson, we get to the main meat of this theory and start asking why?

The change from Windows 3.1 to Windows 95 is the first place this happened. Although Windows 95 sold like hotcakes, it was the dawn of a new idea. The Start menus, for example, was something new, and DOS (16-bit computing) was still limiting everything. Hardware also had to play some catchup, and more and more manufacturers meant more drivers were needed. It was the newness of the ideas that led to Windows 95 being a little

buggy for my taste, because although the ideas were brilliant, it took 3 more years of Microsoft working on them to perfect them in Windows 98. The same applies for Windows ME. Although the shift to NTFS would prove to be the best move Microsoft made in XP, it was the initial newness of the idea that didn't fly. Why upgrade? Why settle for something that seems rushed when my PC works just fine with 98?

XP came along and blew us away. And it was a great OS. A lot of us geeks at the time earned our fame by becoming XP-erts. Keyboard shortcuts and typed commands set us apart from the regular users. Heck, I bet I can still recite the popular serial number for "free" re-installations. HX2BJ-YJTTY-T27MD... yup, I can!

So what was wrong with Vista? To be honest, perhaps not as much as we'd like to believe! What was really wrong with Vista was that Microsoft threw a spanner in their own money-making machine by delaying it. Those five years (August 2001 to November 2006) were perhaps the most iconic in the PC penetration game. People who had never felt the need to use a PC were now being drawn into the technology world. And thanks to XP, could do so on "older" hardware, which was cheaper. Plus, Microsoft had us used to needing an upgrade every three years. It was during XP's unopposed 5-year reign that people got used to the idea that a PC bought in, say, 2002 was still a bonafide computing device in 2006. You could just throw more RAM at the problem (or reinstall) and Windows XP would gain a fresh lease of life.

Then came Vista, with all its highly-flighty needs – wanting GBs of RAM to run, needing a GPU to even run Aero (which was the only reason to want to

upgrade anyway), and everyone hated it. Better the devil you know, even if it's not as good-looking a devil. This changed, of course, when the next upgrade cycle bit us, and we all wanted dual-core and quad-core CPUs, a GPU for HD video and gaming, and not just on a desktop, but on laptops as well. Vista was forgotten, and Windows 7 was just assumed to be the logical upgrade from XP. Add to it the fact that the short netbook phase with unheard of battery lives also reminded everyone that XP certainly still was lighter on hardware, and Vista was always doomed. As for Windows 8, well that's what the next story is about, so we'll leave it at that. In the end, it seems that Microsoft may have actually done a good job with every OS they brought out, and who knows, perhaps they themselves expect every alternate OS to fail, or at the very least, suffer criticism at our hands. Perhaps they know that we're resistant to change, and need a little goading to want to upgrade. Perhaps there is a storm cooking for Windows 9, and Windows 8 was just the survey form (much like Windows Vista was) – put out an OS that's sort of there, but wait for feedback and failure before perfecting it.

I for one certainly hope so... I'd hate to live in a world where Microsoft becomes irrelevant. Apple and Android make great consumption devices, but I'm not yet ready to start creating everything on one of those... I will still need Microsoft to provide me with a platform to do my research, have 60 tabs open in Chrome and type out thousands of words (my iPad doesn't cut it).

I'm doing all that now on a powerful Windows 7 laptop (without a silly touch screen), and wouldn't upgrade to Windows 8 even if Microsoft paid me to! 



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